

Saint Severus of Antioch

Cathedral Homily 41

HOMILY 41

On the Forty Holy Martyrs. This is the second. It was delivered when the homily from the previous year was read again to the people, for they had requested it when it was first preached.

Amos, that astonishing and remarkable man among the prophets, constrained to humility and sincerity and having taken the measure of his lowliness before God's grand and sublime call, fled from the honor and burden of prophecy—and that completely—as he will say at the end (Amos 7:14-15): "I did not present myself as a prophet, I myself, nor did I come as a prophet's son, and it was not of my own free will that I came to such an office": he believed he was hearing something like the sound of a trumpet, while the breath from on high, coming from the Spirit, terrified him and made him tremble; or (like) a roaring lion, while terror works in those who hear him, both with prudence and with fear; he said (Amos 3:6, 8): "If the trumpet sounds in the city, is not the people alarmed? The lion roars—who would not fear? The Lord God speaks—who would not prophesy?"

Therefore I too, while I would wish to be silent at this moment, as I feel a sentiment like this prophet's, say: since the forty martyrs have illustrated and honored this present solemnity, who will keep silent? Who will not dance in spirit, when one is about to be illumined by the lofty deeds and splendid actions of these heroes?

Similarly, just as when the conduct and life of those who then lived in the flesh, as they waged these battles, were honored in every respect, took the lead in the assault at the front rank of the battle, and roused courage among their comrades-in-arms—these God-fearing men, with this spectacle of courage and valor as proof—in the same way even now, as upon a "podium," they appear to sustain the magnificent contest of martyrdom: they also give confidence to the weak to fight together in circumstances like their own; and as for those who, like me, do not know how to speak, they lift them up to pronounce their praise, and they seem to tell me: "Do not imagine, O excellent one, that the whole debt of our praises is paid off by you because you took the trouble to preach a homily about us: you have not yet preached forty panegyrics. For it is not because we fought the sacred contest of martyrdom together that you may suppose we had but one martyrdom and not many: only the arena of the contest was common, as well as our having chosen to suffer for Christ."

"But each of us gave personal proof of his constancy, and we were not all joined together at one and the same time, one with another, in each of the trials that provoked our sufferings; yet we did not suffer any less for that. However, because, having been together under the yoke, we were judged worthy to suffer together, for this reason abundant words and thoughts present themselves in sufficient measure to furnish you with matter for speaking."

Just as the river that flows from Eden and waters Paradise, dividing into four branches (Genesis 2:10-14), filled those four great rivers, so too we, as from a spring from which unceasing, overflowing blessings pour forth—from the forty-day fast, that fast which

irrigates without measure the spiritual paradise of God, we mean the Church—flow forth in forty rivers. Thus indeed, having been instructed during these holy days, we abstained from all passion, we mortified these members upon the earth, and we too adorned ourselves with the crowns of martyrdom; and so, borne on streams still more abundant, we landed in the depths of your spirit: heed only that word, through him who proclaims in sorrow, "Open wide your mouth and I will fill it" (Psalm 81:10). And it comes to me to say what precisely the wise man says (Sirach 24:30-31): "I said, 'I will water my garden and irrigate my flowerbeds, and behold, my channel became a river, and my river, a sea.'"

Shall I then, I alone, be able to restrain such a lack of confidence? Come then, help me with these encomia: when, in place of flowers, we gather the diverse and manifold exploits of the martyrs, from all of them we weave one single manifold crown.

How, indeed, when they were forty, were they not drawn by the manifold ties of matter that urged them from below? Did they not claim the land of their fathers—that which lies on the earth, that land held so sweet by men—and did they not turn their action and their name toward their fathers, which is generally sweeter still than the land of their fathers? Did they not let themselves be overcome by the bond of marriage, which in love is reckoned all the more violent the farther one is away? Yet none of them preferred his children, nor did any cling jealously to his youth; rather, they compared brothers and the rest of the burdens of this fleshly kinship to leaves that fall at the very moment they dry up.

But fear, too, did not pierce the unconquered soul of these heroes. For their leader was Christ, who said to his Father concerning those who believe in him: "As you, Father, are in me, and I in you, so may they be in us, that they may be one" (John 17:21). Hence one force concentrated in the promptness of their thought, one manner of speaking, one vision, one walk, one bearing, without trembling before the tribunal's judgment seat and before this doubling of soul and body: confidence, valor, implacability, inflexibility before riots, intrepidity before threats, eagerness before torments, to the point of even going to meet the contrivances of torture. They mock everything, because they have everything at hand by which to endure every trial, even if each of them needed a second body. But the girdle of glory, the rewards given to those who have served after the death of their patrons, and the honors coming from those who reign on earth—these, they thought, were nothing but an object of contempt and a dream for men overcome by drunken sleep.

Indeed, the whole spirit of these athletes of religion had already embraced and was clinging to the heroism of the kingdom of heaven: everything here below, they considered mortal, their hopes having been turned toward that life without end; and behold, already in spirit they had established themselves on high; and, insofar as they were required only to fight, they lived in the body, resembling, in their firmness and impregnability on every side, a mighty fortress built of immovable, chosen stones, rising toward the heights.

That is why their judge at that time, treacherous and perverse in his devices, as he encircled them on every side, acted to terrify the spirit of these heroes, so lofty and imperturbable. Like someone who sets

up a hedge and schemes against them, sometimes he would flatter them with treacherous, deceitful turmoil, sometimes frighten them with threats; finally, seeing that everything was reduced to nothing and that people strove in vain, with no means of access found, he sent them away. And, as a new kind of torture was being prepared, it occurred to him, as he observed the north wind blowing, which had become still more biting, that this wind would suffice to freeze any damp surface and likewise to cut the breath from every living creature, while the heat that grips every living being flees and rushes at once to the depths below. In the pond nearby, he had these valiant men cast in, utterly naked.

When he had ordered them to be left there to suffer through the whole night, or rather, if we must speak more exactly, to be buried alive in those icy waters, the peril they underwent was thus unveiled and set before everyone's eyes. But these men spent that night, full though it was of torments, as though in delight; for, in place of orders issued by army commanders, they exhorted one another to courage with psalms and praises, and by this means multiplied still further their gladness.

I will pass over in silence the contempt they showed for the bath—the hot bath set before them at hand as if to seduce them—which could have drawn those who preferred bodily life away from the contest. On the other hand, I will also omit the one who was stationed before the bath; after the example of Matthew, who was sitting at the tax office and was called at once by Jesus (Matthew 9:9), another athlete was supplied who, at that same moment, of his own will called out to the saints and took the place

of the one who had wavered and abandoned his rank. But on one point alone, more than all the others, I am filled with admiration: how he who wisely guides our salvation acts. He permitted this so that, through this kind of punishment, the forty martyrs might remain complete.

Indeed, we hear David and these three children praising the Lord and calling all creation to themselves, urging it to reinforce their own praise (Psalm 148:1-14; Daniel 3:52-90): for they command that all things praise and bless the One who made them—heaven and earth, sun and moon, fire and water, animals and wild beasts—not so that these living things, that is, beings without reason or perception, might give forth the sound of a voice, but so that we, in spirit, might turn toward each of them and give thanks to the One who bestowed them as gifts, and that we might unite these creatures, which are set against one another, into one harmony, and gather for our benefit this praise from all creatures.

This, then, also took place in the martyrs' contests. For many of these valiant martyrs were handed over to torture by fire. Tyrants, in different ages, persecuted the faith, and these heroes were not conquered by flame or conflagration; but either by extinguishing it they overcame it, or by the way they bore it they treated it as something cold. Thus fire and heat blessed the Lord, conquered by the steadfastness of those who fought, and thereby gave us occasion to bless as well.

(The tyrants) buried others in the waves of the sea or of rivers, after fastening them to stones or to some other object that dragged them down; or again they were cast alive to the edge of the sea and onto

the land; they finished their course in the midst of the waters and floated on the water's surface like lighter bodies. And so rivers and sea, in their turn, blessed the Lord of the sea.

Animals, too, bless the Lord by means of martyrs when they are set before them as food; but because among the martyrs' victories there was still lacking, to bless the One who made them, cold and chill, snow and frost, we have seen these granted in the forty martyrs with abundance and great profusion. Honoring their triumphs, Christ, the organizer of these contests, plunges us today into the overflowing waves of the sea, while the earth has been all but dried out by fire and the budding of the seeds has wilted. Therefore let us also give honor to those who have fought the good fight (2 Timothy 4:7), and to the God who has set the contest in the reform of life and in conduct that aims at progress.

Let us offset steadfastness in the cold with continence in the ascetic life and the quenching of passions, leading a pure life instead of fornication; and let us offset the nakedness of the holy bodies by sharing superfluous garments, giving clothing to those who have none. If you are not ashamed of Christ, who stood naked for your sake, be ashamed before the martyrs who fought naked for Christ; be instructed and learn the hope of the life to come, while you are still clinging to this corrupt life and this present world: when you enjoy, when you possess, when you put on clothing, you are wearing what is not your own. For whatever lies beyond what you need is not yours. Hear Paul when he says, "When we have food and raiment, let that be enough for us" (1 Timothy 6:8); "but if we have hope only in this life, we are the most miserable of all men" (1 Corinthians

15:19).

Do you see that this single fact of thinking upon the martyrs' deeds—though I do not say that we speak of them with zeal—demands of us sources of virtue far more abundant still? What then? Shall I end the homily and, through silence, steal away the brave tale of this mother, friend of God? Or rather, shall I cheat your God-loving ears of the encomium upon this most beautiful story? But even if I were unwilling, this valiant woman would draw me to it, for I think I see her now, carrying her son upon her shoulders—this woman so manly in spirit, loving her son, who conducted the weakness of her nature with such energy, and ran behind the she-ass as best she could, and said in her distress: "I fear that God, who knows the depths of hearts, may have seen in me fleshly thought, or a woman's tears without strength and courage, and that to soothe my faint-heartedness he may have allowed my son to draw breath, while the others made so noble a departure and their bodies passed through the fire at the command of their judge."

"How could I endure all this shipwreck and frustration? If the mothers of those who finished with my son this athletic contest already possess in heaven the fruit of their own intimate birth pangs, the fruit of my womb, by contrast, is still on earth. Do not reject my sacrifice, O my Lord, as you rejected Cain's (Genesis 4:5). For though I may have offered it without righteousness, with righteousness I have not shrunk back as he did. For I offer you my son wholly, not with a divided heart, and I have kept nothing back for myself: there is but one rule and zeal that I have laid upon myself in declaring that he belongs to you: behold, you have my son on the

she-ass, as Isaac when he was set upon the wood (Genesis 22:9). For I took hold of him as I ran—I ran knowingly—emulating the course of Paul (Philippians 3:12-14). Therefore, on the day of the resurrection, pay me the goat—the one you have given us as a gift, your Son and Lamb—in the plantation of Sabek (Genesis 22:13) as a victim of purification; but the plantation of Sabek is the holy cross, for it is the wood of remission and pardon."

Such are the words, actions, and thoughts of this courageous mother. May mothers in this resemble her; may they feel nothing alien to piety when they see their sons devoted to the work beloved of God; and if one of you sees her son fasting, let her further encourage his zeal with wise and fervent exhortation, and not by looking at the pallor of his face. Before participation in suffering, it is not fitting that she should faint, grow slack, and be weakened. Let her cast off the thought that sprang up too hastily! If she finds him on his way to the church, persevering in the night office and in prayer, let her rejoice with him over his progress and together with him increase her store of riches.

And you too must keep your sons from taking the pernicious and harmful path of the spectacles—that is, horse races, shameful songs, and mimes. You may think you are exhorting and flattering them, but when you sometimes give these things, sometimes promise them, and use other such means, you only flatter them, entice them, and drag them into corruption. For upon malleable clay, in the growing season of youth, the lessons of virtue or of vice are engraved; and so they stand in need of discipline that is steady and laborious.

Let us also pray that the contests and athletic crownings of these martyrs—their noble victory and their many honors—may remain before our eyes through our whole life, so that in times like these we may not abandon the truth, and that when we are overwhelmed by passions we may not be swept into a profane spirit, but that, living and conducting ourselves in fear and trembling (Philippians 2:12), we may be worthy of the kingdom of heaven, to receive it whole through the grace and love of the great God and our Savior Jesus Christ, to whom, with the Father, belong glory, honor, and power, together with the Holy Spirit, equal in essence, now and always, and unto ages of ages. Amen.